11. Childbirth, mother-and-baby care, and medicinal plants

Oracle OS guide. Manuals in the library: Hesperian "A Book for Midwives", "Where There Is No Doctor", WHO "Pregnancy, Childbirth, Postpartum and Newborn Care", MSF Obstetrics, Culpeper "Complete Herbal", WikiMed/MDWiki. This guide does not replace a trained midwife: train at least two people per community.

Pregnancy — follow-up

- Varied food (pulses, eggs, dark greens, fish), clean water, rest. Avoid alcohol, smoking and abortifacient herbs (rue, pennyroyal, mugwort, tansy).
- Measure the belly monthly: the top of the womb rises ~1 cm per week from 20 weeks (navel ≈ 20–22 weeks).
- **Danger signs in pregnancy** — get the most trained person now: vaginal bleeding; bad headache, blurred vision, sudden swelling of face/hands or fits (pre-eclampsia/eclampsia); fever; waters breaking before 37 weeks; baby stops moving; strong constant belly pain.

Prepare for the birth (clean kit)

Soap, boiled water, clean boiled cloths, 2 boiled ties/strings, a new razor blade or scissors boiled 20 min, gloves or washed hands and short nails, a blanket for the baby, a container for the placenta, a torch. **The "3 cleans": clean hands, clean surface, clean cord cut.**

Labour (normal)

1. **Opening**: regular contractions getting stronger; let the mother walk, drink, pee, choose her position. First baby: often 12 h or more.
2. **Pushing**: urge to push; support the perineum with a cloth, let the head come out slowly. If the cord is loose around the neck, slip it over the head.
3. Baby out: dry, skin-to-skin on the mother's chest, cover. If not breathing: dry and rub the back, clear mouth/nose, head slightly back, 5 gentle breaths covering nose+mouth, then ~40 breaths/min; if the heart is below 60 after 1 min of breaths, two-thumb compressions (3:1).
4. **Cord**: wait 1–3 min (or until it stops pulsing), tie in two places (2 and 5 cm from the baby), cut between them with a clean blade. Keep it dry, put nothing on it.
5. **Placenta**: normally comes within 30 min. Don't pull hard on the cord. Then rub the womb (it should feel hard like a ball) and put the baby to the breast — both reduce bleeding. Check the placenta is complete.

Birth emergencies — recognise

- **Postpartum haemorrhage** (> 500 ml, or the mother turns pale, dizzy, fast pulse): continuous womb massage, baby at the breast, empty the bladder, legs raised, fluids; if misoprostol/oxytocin is in the kit, use as the manual says. Bimanual compression (midwives' manual). It is the #1 cause of maternal death.

- Pushing stage > 2 h without progress or labour stalled > 12 h; transverse baby; arm or cord coming first; difficult breech; fever with bad smell; fits. See the specific chapters in the manual.

After the birth and the newborn

- Breastfeed in the first hour and on demand (8–12 times/day); colostrum is precious. Keep the baby warm (skin-to-skin, hat).
- Watch the mother for 6 weeks: fever, foul-smelling blood, belly pain → infection (see Where There Is No Doctor).
- Danger signs in the baby: not feeding, cold or feverish, fast (> 60/min) or grunting breathing, yellow skin within 24 h, red/pus-filled navel, fits.
- Space pregnancies ≥ 2 years: exclusive breastfeeding protects only in the first 6 months and while periods have not returned (LAM method).

Medicinal plants — prudent use

Rules: identify with certainty (2 sources, see the Plants module), start with low doses, one plant at a time, nothing in pregnancy without certainty, children half or less. Teas: 1 tablespoon dried herb (or 2 fresh) per cup; infusion for leaves/flowers (10 min covered), decoction for roots/bark (boil 10–15 min).

- **Chamomile**: digestion, mild colic, gentle calming.
- **Peppermint**: nausea, gas (avoid with strong reflux and in babies).
- **Ginger**: nausea (including morning sickness at food doses), colds.
- **Garlic**: mild antimicrobial in food; raw crushed on wounds can burn — dilute.
- **Plantain (Plantago)**: chewed/crushed leaf on stings, small wounds; tea for cough.
- **Calendula**: salve/oil for skin, superficial wounds, nappy rash.
- **Yarrow (Achillea)**: stops minor bleeding in wounds (not in pregnancy).
- **Willow bark**: pain and fever (contains salicylates) — not for children, aspirin allergy or ulcers.
- **Thyme**: cough, sore throat (gargle).
- **Elder (flowers; berries only cooked)**: colds, fever.
- **Echinacea**: start of colds (short term).
- **Honey**: cough (never babies < 1 year), wounds (pure honey as a dressing).
- **Valerian**: insomnia, anxiety.
- **Comfrey**: external only, on bruises — toxic to the liver if swallowed.
- **Dangerous** look-alikes: hemlock (looks like wild carrot/parsley), foxglove, deadly nightshade, monkshood, yew. If in doubt, don't use it.
- Dry in the shade, store in dark labelled jars with name and date (keeps ~1 year).